Angeline the Baker

Old Time • Key of D • G Diatonic Harmonica • 2nd Position • AABB Form

Composed by Stephen Foster (1850) • Old-Time Jam Standard

Watch Part 1 — Lower Octave

Watch Part 2 — Mid/High Octave

Notation: " = whole tone bend tah/yah dah = tongue articulation shada dee shada = fox chase rhythm

Reference Scale — Major Pentatonic, 2nd Position:

```
(-1 +2) -2 -"3 -4 +5 +6 -6 -7 -8 +8 +9 (-10)
```

A Part — Play Twice (Lower Octave)

Basic Melody

```
-1 +2 +3 (tah) -1 +2 +3 -2 -yahdah
-1 +2 +3 -1 +2 +shadadee shada
-1 +2 +3 -tah -"3 -3 -"3 -2
-1 +2 +3  -3 -"3 +3 +2 -1 -shadadee shada
```

B Part — Play Twice (Lower Octave)

Basic Melody

```
-4 -3 -"3 +3 -"3 -3 -"3 -2 -yahdah
-4 -3 -"3 -2 +2  +shadadee shada
-4 -3 -"3 +3 -"3 -3 -"3 -2
-1 +2 +3  -3 -"3 +3 +2 -1 -shadadee shada
```

© GT Harmonica 2026. All Rights Reserved.

Angeline the Baker

Mid/High Octave

Watch Part 2 — Mid/High Octave

A Part — Play Twice (Mid/High Octave)

Basic Melody

```
-4 +5 +6 -yah
-4 +5 +6 +6 +yah
-4 +5 +6 -4 +5 +shadadee shada
-4 +5 +6  -6 -7 -6 +6   -6 -7 -6 +6 +5 -4 -shadadee shada
```

B Part — Play Twice (Mid/High Octave)

Basic Melody

```
-8 -7 -6 +6 -6 -7 -6 +6
-8 -7 -6 +6 +5 +shadadee shada
-8 -7 -6 +6 -6 -7 -6 +6
-4 +5 +6 -7 -6 +6 +5 -4 -shadadee shada
```

Taking It Further

- Transition smoothly from single notes to 4 and 5 hole octaves
- Add rhythmic variations — fox chase rhythm underneath the melody
- Move between lower and mid/high octaves within the same pass
- Work on dynamics — quiet on the verses, push on the B part climbs

© GT Harmonica 2026. All Rights Reserved.

Angeline the Baker

Watch Part 1 — Lower Octave

Watch Part 2 — Mid/High Octave

Origins

"Angelina Baker" was composed by Stephen Foster in 1850 and published as a minstrel song for the Christy Minstrels. Foster (1826–1864) was one of America's most prolific songwriters, responsible for classics like Oh! Susanna, Camptown Races, and My Old Kentucky Home. The original song tells the story of a slave lamenting the loss of a woman named Angelina who has been "sent away" — a euphemism for being sold. It's important to acknowledge this context while recognising the tune's enduring place in the tradition.

Over the decades, the song shed its lyrics and evolved into a purely instrumental fiddle tune. The instrumental version, as collected by John A. Lomax, differs somewhat from Foster's original melody — shaped by generations of fiddlers, banjo players, and string bands who passed it along by ear, each adding their own character. The name shifted too, from Angelina Baker to the now standard Angeline the Baker. Today it sits firmly in the old-time canon alongside tunes like Soldier's Joy and Turkey in the Straw.

A Jam Session Standard

Angeline the Baker is one of the essential tunes for anyone wanting to sit in at an old-time jam. It's commonly played in the keys of D, G, and occasionally C, following an AABB form. You'll hear it at festivals, pub sessions, and front porch gatherings across the country. Knowing this tune opens doors — it's one of those melodies that everyone in the circle will recognise, and being able to hold it down on harmonica marks you as someone who knows the tradition.

One version worth seeking out is by the late banjo player Dwight Diller (1948–2023), whose playing had a beautiful mellow sound with amazing dynamics and a very cool groove. Diller was a key figure in preserving the clawhammer banjo tradition of Pocahontas County, West Virginia, and his recordings of Angeline are among the finest out there.

Playing This Tune

This version is played in second position on a G diatonic harmonica in the key of D. The lower octave version sits around holes 1–4, using tongue articulations (tah, yah dah) and the fox chase rhythm (shada dee shada) to drive the tune forward. The mid/high octave version moves up to holes 4–9, giving the melody a brighter, more cutting quality that works well for leading the tune in a session.

Start with the lower octave to get the melody and rhythm locked in, then move up to the high version. Once you're comfortable with both, try moving between the two within the same pass through the tune — that's where it really starts to come alive. The reference scale (major pentatonic in 2nd position) runs from -1 up to +9, and knowing it will help you find your way around the melody in both octaves.

© GT Harmonica 2026. All Rights Reserved.